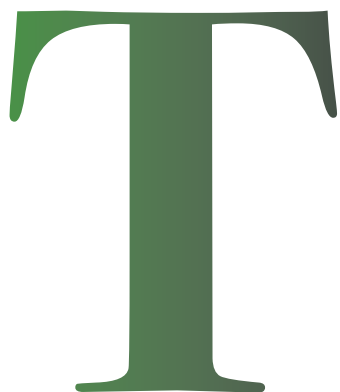




THE AROMA OF freshly fried *jalebis*, a treat in many Indian households, used to be a siren call for Rohan, a Bengaluru-based software engineer battling an expanding waistline. Like many in a city known for sedentary work and rich food, the 36-year-old's health markers are starting to raise an alarm. He is combing online to learn about drugs such as Ozempic and Wegovy that are generating a buzz for their use in weight management.

70 | Rohan's case depicts a new reality in India where rising obesity is providing an opportunity for global pharmaceutical giants. Take Novo Nordisk. The Danish company, known for semaglutide—which has made waves globally for its effectiveness in treating obesity and Type 2 diabetes—is looking to make India central to its growth plans. The reason is simple. The company, after years of steady growth, is showing signs of strain from increased competition and regulations in developed markets. It is undergoing a significant leadership reshuffle amid pressure from investors following a sharp decline in its share price over the past year. CEO Lars Fruergaard Jørgensen, who has led the company since 2017, recently announced his decision to step down, weeks after Executive Vice President Camilla Sylvest exited the firm.

India was not initially on Novo's radar. It had planned to launch Wegovy, its flagship weight-loss drug, in India around 2026. However, with growing global demand, competition from American pharmaceutical giant Eli Lilly's diabetes-cum-weight-loss drug

Mounjaro and imminent launch of the generic versions of the drug, it is accelerating its India plans. The patent for semaglutide is expiring in 2026.

WHY INDIA

A faster expansion in India will allow Novo to diversify growth and tap into a market with significant potential for obesity-related treatments. According to ICMR-INDIAB national study (ICMR-INDIAB-17), published in *The Lancet Diabetes and Endocrinology*, about 254 million had generalised obesity, and 351 million had abdominal obesity in India. The condition is notably higher among women, 40% of whom are affected, compared to men (12%). The obesity treatment market is currently valued at ₹3,000-3,500 crore, with projections suggesting it could balloon to ₹25,000 crore by 2030, as per an IMARC report. Novo wants to gain a foothold in this rapidly growing segment before Indian pharmaceutical giants such as Sun Pharma, Cipla, Lupin and Dr. Reddy's launch their generic versions.

The response to Eli Lilly's Mounjaro, already available in India at a relatively lower price, signals the competition is intensifying. "Obesity is a chronic disease that requires comprehensive management. Lilly is committed to enhancing the standard of care in obesity management in India. Results from SURMOUNT-5, a phase 3b open-label clinical trial published in *The New England Journal of Medicine*, demonstrated that Mounjaro (tirzepatide), a dual GIP and GLP-1 receptor agonist, led to greater weight reduction than Wegovy (semaglutide)," says Winselov Tucker, President and General Manager, Eli Lilly and Company (India).

Fast-tracking Wegovy's launch will give Novo more time to stay ahead of the generic versions that are expected to flood the market after the semaglutide patent expires. The decision is rooted in patient need, regulatory preparedness and a clear shift in public health priorities, says Vikrant Shrotriya, Managing Director, Novo Nordisk India. "We are introducing Wegovy (injectable semaglutide 2.4 mg), which offers the full therapeutic strengths of semaglutide for comprehensive management of weight and obesity, this year," says Shrotriya. "As a healthcare company, we acknowledge responsibility towards our patients to ensure availabil-

The global obesity drug market is expected to soar to over ₹8.3 lakh crore (\$100 billion) annually by the end of the decade